



THE QUEST: Scholars in Patna deliberate on Kalidas

A Birthplace for the Bard

Archaeologists and scholars of Mithila try to trace the venerated Sanskrit poet Kalidas' early years

■ By Farzand Ahmed

First it was the efforts to trace the native origins of "international Indians" like astronaut Sunita Williams, now scholars and archaeologists in Bihar have staked a claim to poet Kalidas. Recently, about 60 scholars gathered at the Patna division of Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) in a bid to trace and preserve the birthplace of Kalidas, whose life and times are shrouded in mystery. After a daylong discourse, scholars agreed to ASI's Superintending Archaeologist Dr Phani Kant Mishra's suggestion to launch excavations to support the belief that Kalidas was born in the Madhubani-Darbhanga region.

"After the current floods recede, a team of archaeologists would visit Uchaith, believed to be the birthplace of Kalidas," Mishra said. However, Bihar Religious Trusts Board Administrator and Sanskrit scholar Kishore Kunal, who presided over the ASI meet, later admitted that the time and place of birth of Kalidas may not be established by excavations. "Mithila's claim over Kalidas is based on the fact that he had compared lips with 'bimb-phala', a fruit found in the region," he said.

Different regions claim Kalidas as their own. Bengal scholars maintain Kalidas was a Bengali because of his name



(Kali + Das) and Kalidas Research Committee organises an annual Kalidas Utsav. They also believe he was born in Gadda Singru village in Murshidabad. Kashmiri scholars say in *Kumarsambhavam* and *Meghdootum* his description of the Himalayan region matched with Kashmir. Ujjain calls Kalidas its own as he was a gem in the court of Vikramaditya (Chandragupta-II), the place of his principal literary activities. Oriya scholars claim he was born at Ramagiri in Orissa. Many believe he was a native of Ramtek in Madhya Pradesh and it was here that he penned *Meghdootum*.

Sahitya Akademy awardee Govind Jha says there are songs in his dramas that match Maithili folk songs. Besides, he says, Kalidas might have shifted to Ujjain. In the 18th century, Sir George Abraham Grierson, the man behind the Linguistic Survey of India, found Kalidih, the birthplace of Kalidas, in Uchaith, says Jha. Kalidas is believed to have gained wisdom in Siddhipitha temple here, which also housed his *pathshala*. In local dialect and survey records it is mentioned as Kaildasko Chaupdi, the college of Kalidas.

Archaeologists believe the site is very old and an excavation might yield good results. Even as scholars may agree to disagree over the great bard's birthplace, he continues to enthrall one and all everywhere.